Course Outline Template

Indian Institute of Management Calcutta

Programme: MBA

Name of the Course: Management and Marketing Lessons in Political Campaigns

Core / Elective: Elective

Cap (for Elective): 1 section only

Credit: 1.5

Academic Year & Term: 2026-27, Term VI (Pre Mid-Term)

Course Coordinator: Prof. Prashant Mishra

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Instructor: Prof. Shreyans Mehta (Session - 10) **Affiliation:** ……..

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Instructor: ……(Sessions … – …) **Affiliation:** ……..

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Introduction to Course /Course Description

Politics, for a long time, was viewed in India as an unprofessional and unstructured space which did not employ managerial practices. The 2014 election in India changed this paradigm on its head. Professional campaign teams were deployed on the ground for some of the most hi-tech campaigns like 3-D rallies, data analytics and social media outreach. These changes have completely transformed the political landscape of today across states and political outfits.

Just like politics has changed its view about professionals in India and is learning from them, the reverse is also true. Imagine a marketing professional who needs to sell the same product to over a billion people from all kinds of geographic, economic, social and psychographic segments! For any marketing expert, this

belies every marketing concept learnt about segmentation, targeting, developing niches etc. And yet, every 5 years, this phenomenon repeats in this diverse country. Could there be something that management professionals of today could learn from the way politicians run their campaigns?

This course helps develop in participants a broad understanding of how political campaigns use management ideas. At the same time, it emphasizes on the lessons professionals can derive from arguably the biggest marketing exercise of the country – the Indian democratic election! This course, by being at the intersection of management and political campaigning, offers an opportunity for cross-domain learning for B-school students.

Course Objective and Key-takeaways from the course

This course helps participants understand the significance of management and marketing in politics and also enables them to derive management lessons from political campaigns. The course has multiple objectives

a. Understand political campaigns as a marketing exercise, and learn how marketing theories and frameworks get applied to politics
b. Derive management and leadership insights from political campaigns
c. Practical application of political and marketing insights to specific brands and/or election campaigns

Programme Level Learning Goals (7)

a. Analyze brands from multiple marketing and management frameworks which are also relevant in the political context

b. Understand elections as a marketing exercise and how management frameworks are relevant to politics

c. Understand how concepts like STP can be applied in broad contexts like politics where audiences tend to be heterogeneous

d. Understand how brands build deep loyalty using examples from the space of politics where people get easily moved by political brands

e. Understand storytelling as a powerful means of communicating personal and brand stories

f. Understand the work done by political consultants and help participants figure out if they have an inclination towards the same

g. Figure out frameworks which can enable the participants to be better managers and leaders

Mapping to Program Level Learning Goals

Design Thinking for Products and Services:

	Goal 1	**Goal 2**	**Goal 3**	**Goal 4**	**Goal 5**	**Goal 6**	**Goal 7**
	Critical Thinking	Acquiring Ethical Values	Acquiring Global Perspective	Ability to Articulate	Technological Competencies	Problem Solving	Leadership Qualities

DTPS	b, c			e		a, c, d	g

International Components in your course (if any)

Apart from the readings, the course brings in international components through contemporary cases as well as examples cited in the classes.

Pre-requisites: N/A

Required Text Book(s): None

Recommended Text Book(s)

Kotler, P., Keller, K. L. (2016), "Marketing Management", Pearson.
Lees-Marshment J. (2014), "Political Marketing Principles and Applications", Routledge

Course Pack Distribution to students:

a. Shama, A. (1975). An Analysis of Political Marketing. In Zaltman G. and Sternthal B. (eds.), Broadening the Concept of Consumer Behavior, 106-116. Cincinnati, OH : Association for Consumer Research.
b. Tucker, D. and Teo, D. (2017, Dec 06). Obama Campaign rewrites fundraising rules by selling merchandise. Retrieved from https://www.huffpost.com/entry/obama-campaign-rewrites-f_b_140616
c. Bryson, M. & McDill, W. (1968). The Political Spectrum: A Bi-Dimensional Approach. *Rampart Journal of Individualist Thought, 4(2)*, 27-31.
d. Court D., Elzinga D., Mulder S. & Vetvik O.J. (2009, June). The Consumer Decision Journey. Retrieved from: https://www.mckinsey.com/capabilities/growth-marketing-and-sales/our insights/the-consumer-decision journey
e. Duarte, N. (2020, May 06). Good Leadership Is About Communicating "Why". Harvard Business Review. Retrieved from: https://hbr.org/2020/05/good-leadership-is-about-communicating-why
f. Sinek S. (2009, September). Simon Sinek: How great leaders inspire action. Retrieved from: https://www.ted.com/talks/simon_sinek_how_great_leaders_inspire_action?language=en g. Singh, A. (2019, May 22). New socio-political churn reshaping India?. Observer Research Foundation. Retrieved from:
h. https://www.orfonline.org/expert-speak/new-socio-political-churn-reshaping-india-51126/ i. George J.M. and Jones, G.R. (2009). Understanding and Managing Organizational Behavior. Delhi: Pearson Education, Inc.
j. Collins, J. (2001). Level 5 Leadership-The Triumph of Humility and Fierce Resolve, Harvard Business Review, January, 67-76
k. Sinnreich, A. (2018, June 12). Cambridge Analytica: Tip of the Iceberg as Deep as the Ocean. The Globepost. Retrieved from https://theglobepost.com/2018/06/12/cambridge-analytica-data-democracy/
l. Pant, S.(2019, Apr 16). Why this is India's big data election. The Times of India. Retrieved from: https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/elections/news/why-this-is-indias-big-data-election/articlesh

ow/68898005.cms
m. Venugopal, V. (2014, May). Narendra Modi's Citizens for Accountable Governance (CAG): Will it be disbanded or play bigger role? Retrieved from: https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/news/economy/policy/narendra-modis-citizens-for-accountable-governance-cag-will-it-be-disbanded-or-play-bigger-role/articleshow/35131371.cms?from=mdr

n. Pathak, S. & Patra R. (2015). Evolution of Political Campaign in India. International Journal of Research and Scientific Innovation (IJRSI), 2,55-59.
o. Ali, A. (2021, June 26) Different route - The Congress's path to revival lies in it proving its valency. Retrieved from: https://www.telegraphindia.com/amp/opinion/the-congresss-path-to-revival-lies-in-it-proving-its valency/cid/1820103?__twitter_impression=true
p. Kumar S., Alam M. S. & Joshi D. (2008). Caste dynamics and political process in Bihar. Journal of Indian School of Political Economy, 20(2), 1-32.

Technology enabled learning component for your course: N/A

Session Plan

S No.	Topic	Intended learning outcome	References
1	Politics and Marketing: The Fundamental Similarity		in politics b) Learning management lessons on building loyalty using political examples
2	The Marketing Strategy for Political Parties: STP	5 The Political Organization: The campaign management backbone a) To understand the interrelationship between politics and marketing b) To be able to see the application of management concepts across industries	a) To understand how to structure communication to make it effective b)To learn a key tool of political communication – storytelling and understand how some brands use this tool successfully while others struggle with it.
3	Voter: Dutiful citizen, Loyal consumer, Passionate crusader	a) To understand application of the product concept vis-a-vis the marketing concept in a political context b) To understand how segmentation, targeting and positioning works in case of a deeply diverse audience like in the case of politics	a) To understand the role of organizational structure, culture, leadership, organizational learning, and volunteer motivation in managing a successful political campaign
4	Marketing communication: The skill to connect to your consumers	a) Understanding of the application of marketing funnels	4 PPT, reference book and readings mentioned above

course handout, class notes

PPT, reference book and readings mentioned above

PPT, reference book and readings mentioned above

PPT, reference book, readings in

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6	The Role of Professionals in Politics	b) To derive insights into how different organizations differ basis these organizational elements a) To understand the role of professionals in politics in 1) Market Research and Data Analytics 2) Social Media Marketing 3) Field Campaign Management 4) Hi-Tech Political Campaigns b) To understand political consulting as an industry	PPT, reference book and readings mentioned above
7-8	Case Study: Creating a new future for the grand old party of India	a) To don the role of political consultants in these sessions and analyze a political party from an external neutral lens b) To apply course learnings by reflecting on the challenges being faced by the Indian National Congress amidst the unprecedented rise of the BJP over the last decade and provide management solutions for the same c) To understand how management principles can be applied to this case and how could Indian political outfits benefit from the application of these principles	PPT, reference book and readings mentioned above
9-10	Project Work: Application of insights derived to practical business and political scenarios	a) To derive learnings from regional political leaders of India b) To apply management insights to regional political parties of India	PPT, reference book, class notes and readings mentioned above

** Faculty should endeavor to provide as much detail on session-wise topics / readings in the suggested format.

Evaluation Components

✔ Components	✔ Weightage
Class Participation	20%
Quizzes	40%
Group Project	40%